



Buddhist AI Ethics Seminar Series 3 **Buddhism and AI: Reality, Ethics, and Governance**

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Phnom Penh, October 25, 2024 – The Buddhist AI Ethics Seminar Series 3, titled "**Buddhism and AI: Reality, Ethics, and Governance**," convened a diverse group of participants and esteemed speakers to explore the intricate relationships between artificial intelligence (AI) and Buddhist ethical frameworks. This seminar has served as a vital platform for reflection and dialogue on how these two domains can inform one another as we navigate the complexities of modern technology.

Throughout the discussions, participants engaged deeply with fundamental questions surrounding the ethical implications of AI in a world increasingly defined by its rapid advancement. Key inquiries included the essence of humanity in an era dominated by technology and how Buddhist principles can guide the development of ethical frameworks for AI systems. Such deliberations underline the urgent need to examine not just the capabilities of AI but also the moral implications of its deployment in society.

A prominent theme that emerged was the essential role of Buddhist ethics in shaping sustainable and compassionate approaches to AI development. The teachings of non-harming (ahimsa), compassion (មេត្តា) and mindfulness (ស្ម័គ្រចិត្ត) provide critical insights that can be integrated into AI design and governance. By asking how these ethical principles align with technological innovation, the discussions raised vital questions about creating AI technologies that genuinely serve the interests of humanity.

In exploring governance structures for AI, participants examined the significance of defining 'right action' (សម្មាភិក្ខុ/ការងារត្រឹមត្រូវ) within this context. Ethical governance must extend beyond mere compliance and efficiency; it requires a commitment to justice, equity, and well-being of all stakeholders involved. Central to this discussion was a collective recognition of the responsibility to integrate Buddhist moral teachings into leadership practices, fostering a culture that prioritizes the collective welfare of the community over individual gain.

The concept of agency and autonomy emerged as a significant concern during the seminar, illuminating the complexities inherent in our relationship with artificial intelligence (AI) technology, which refers to computer systems designed to perform tasks that typically require human intelligence, such as learning, reasoning, and problem-solving. As society increasingly relies on these AI systems, we must critically consider the implications of surrendering decision-making power to algorithms that simulate human intelligence. This shift raises essential questions about maintaining a balance between technological advancement and the preservation of human judgment. In this context, Buddhist teachings offer valuable insights into wisdom, defined as the ability to make sound judgments and decisions based on a deep understanding of the interconnectedness of all beings. This emphasis on ethical awareness and mindfulness is not merely an ideal, but a fundamental aspect of our humanity. AI, therefore, is reframed as more than just a tool; it becomes a catalyst for profound reflection on human responsibility and moral accountability. As we navigate an ever-evolving technological landscape, this discussion invites us to ensure that the decisions made by algorithms align with our values and collective well-being, thereby reinforcing our agency in a rapidly changing world.





Another critical dimension of the seminar was the exploration of Buddhist economics and its relevance in a technology-driven context, which opens up a transformative lens through which to assess our current economic systems. Participants engaged in a meaningful dialogue about how traditional measures of success – often narrowly focused on material accumulation and GDP growth – must be redefined to encompass ethical considerations that promote holistic well-being and societal flourishing. Buddhist economics advocates for a model that prioritizes human satisfaction, social equity, and environmental stewardship over mere growth, echoing the belief that true prosperity arises not from the relentless pursuit of possessions, but from fostering an environment where individuals and communities can thrive. This approach emphasizes the significance of mindful consumption (ការស្គាល់ប្រមាណក្នុងបរិភោគ ឬប្រើប្រាស់), urging individuals to reflect upon their consumption patterns and the impact they have on the world. Additionally, the principle of interconnectedness (បដិច្ចសមុប្បាទៈ) serves as a foundational tenet, reminding us that every action reverberates through the web of life, thus advocating for sustainable economic practices that honor the intricate relationships among people, communities, and the environment. By integrating these principles into our economic frameworks, we can cultivate a more compassionate and sustainable world that prioritizes the well-being of all living beings, paving the way for a future where technology and human values harmoniously coexist.

The insights gleaned from this seminar challenge participants to reimagine what it means to progress in a world increasingly influenced by AI technologies. By encouraging a shift away from practices that promote consumerism and individualistic pursuits, this dialogue advocates for fostering community, shared values, and collective responsibility.

Moving forward, the integration of Buddhist principles into the governance of AI technologies can serve as a foundational element in addressing the ethical dilemmas posed by their implementation. By emphasizing compassion, non-harming, and mindful awareness, the intersection of Buddhism and technology may pave the way for more ethical, equitable, and inclusive AI systems.

The discussions held during this seminar reinforce the notion that developing ethical AI frameworks is not merely an academic endeavor; it is a moral imperative that calls for active participation across disciplines. Collaborative efforts that draw from insights into technology, philosophy, ethics, and community engagement are essential as society navigates the complex landscape of AI systems. This transformative potential highlights an urgent need for interdisciplinary dialogue, enabling the cultivation of a future where AI serves humanity in a manner that reflects compassion, interconnectedness, and ethical responsibility.

